

On *U*-syncretism and Passives: A Response to Key 2024

Chigchi Bai

Inner Mongolia University of Finance and Economics

chigchi.bai@imufe.edu.cn

Jan 12, 2026

Abstract

Key (2024) claims that *u*-syncretism is a manifestation of morphosyntactic ambiguity, which is attributed to a nonactive Voice head. So-called nonactive Voice does not have a specifier and therefore does not project an external argument. Key (2024) also claims that canonical passives, which are formed from a transitive-marked stem, have a Voice-stacking structure, where the upper Voice is nonactive, thereby deriving the passive, and the lower Voice is active and endowed with a D feature, which is spelled out with transitive marking. This paper shows that Key's (2024) treatment of *u*-syncretism as a manifestation of morphosyntactic ambiguity in Turkish is correct, his attribution of it and passive derivation to the purported nonactive Voice is incorrect. It will be argued that it is the promotion or the referential linking of an internal argument to Spec of a Voice head rather than the active-nonactive Voice variation that gives rise to voice-syncretism subsuming *u*-syncretism. It is demonstrated that external arguments are suppressed in noncanonical (low) passives but not in canonical passives and that there is no active-nonactive variation of Voice as a syntactic head. Syncretic morphology, a passive suffix or a causative one, spells out Voice at varying heights, where Voice always introduces an argument, either external or internal, and there does not exist nonactive Voice in the syntax. Consequently, building voice constructions is reducible to introducing arguments through Voice heads; it is Free Merge of DPs at various heights rather than a feature on Voice that leads to voice variation. Voice syntax is thus simplified, as demanded by Minimalism.

Keywords: *u*-syncretism; Voice; passive; agent; internal argument promotion

1. Introduction

Embick (2004) notes that morphological syncretism is often found with passives, reflexives, and unaccusatives, arguing that they all have “unaccusative syntax”. Embick (2004) concludes that *u*-syncretism is centered on the absence of external arguments by assuming that passives and reflexives lack an external argument in the syntax, as is the case with unaccusatives. Key (2024), one recent representative study, however, proposes that *u*-syncretism, reflecting morphosyntactic ambiguity, is attributed to the absence of a D feature on a Voice head. Key (2024) argues that *u*-syncretism arises only where transitive marking, which is an exponent of a D feature, is null. For Key (2024), the head spelled out by *u*-syncretic passive morphology, for example, *-II* in Turkish, is specifierless. Specifically, Key (2024: 364) concludes that the Turkish passive is built on an active Voice layer, and the agent is not present as a syntactic argument. Key (2024: 364), adopting Bruening's (2013) structure, holds that PassP embeds a layer of active Voice that does not project a specifier.

- (1) a. Passive: [PassP Pass [VoiceP Voice_{active} [vP]]] — canonical passive
b. Anticausative: [VoiceP Voice_{nonactive} [vP]]] — noncanonical passive

(adapted from Key 2024: 335)

Key (2024: 365) identifies Bruening's (2013) Pass(ive) head as specifierless Voice, which lacks a D feature. Thus, for Key (2024), both a higher Voice (Bruening's 2013 Pass) and a lower Voice, which is specified as active, are specifierless and agentless. The two Voice heads, as Key (2024) argues, differ in that the higher one lacks a D feature which the lower one has. It is this D feature on the lower Voice that prevents it from being spelled out as nonactive morphology

such as *-II* but gets it spelled out by active morphology (transitive marker such as *-Dir* as well as its allomorphic variants and *eD* in Turkish). The higher Voice, lacking D, is spelled out as nonactive morphology, which can be modeled as the elsewhere form of Voice (Key 2024: 367).

(2) a. Voice → Voice[NACT] (*-II* etc.)

b. Voice{D} → Voice[CAUSE] (*-Dir* etc.) (Key 2024: 367)

Thus, for Key (2024), passive morphology, being *u*-syncretic, is the exponent of Voice without a D feature, while transitive/causative morphology is that of Voice with a D feature. Key's (2024) D feature, identical to Bruening's (2013) N feature, does not entail an actual DP argument that Voice introduces. Rather, this D feature represents external argument semantics. Notably, postulating a specifierless Voice head for passives (Bruening 2013; Alexiadou 2014; Alexiadou et al. 2015) takes its rise from the wrong assumption that passives always lack a real syntactic external argument.¹ This wrong assumption leads to the correlation of *u*-syncretism to the purported active-nonactive variation of Voice, on the one hand, and the failure to correctly capture the structural distinction and similarity between canonical passives (passives with external argument semantics) and noncanonical passives (passives with no external argument semantics), on the other hand.

Under the active-nonactive approach to passives and Voice, what makes a passive in the syntax is the purported nonactive Voice rather than internal argument promotion; the structural distinctions and similarities between canonical and noncanonical passives thus all come down to the active-nonactive variation of Voice plus formal semantics (Bruening 2013). This entails that internal argument promotion is disassociated from passive morphology and passive semantics of canonical and noncanonical passives, the latter of which being anticausatives. This, however, violates Mirror Principle (Baker 1985).

This paper shows that (1) and (2) are incorrect in approaching passive derivation and *u*-syncretism. Let us use "Voice[−D]" to consistently refer to a Voice head which does not introduce an actual argument and "Voice[+D]" to refer to a Voice head which introduces an argument. Voice_{ACTIVE} and Voice_{NONACTIVE} in (1) are thus both Voice[−D], not Voice[+D]. The postulation of Voice[−D] in various forms has been based on the researchers' presupposition that in passives, the voice proper, agents are absent from the syntax (Pylkkänen 2008; Schäfer 2008, 2015; Bruening 2013; Legate 2014; Alexiadou et al. 2015; Legate et al. 2020). However, there is solid evidence that agents are syntactic arguments in canonical passives (cf. Section 2). So-called agent-suppression in canonical passives is thus illusive. This paper shows that what is suppressed in canonical passives is in fact INITIATOR rather than an agent. The idea behind this is that the agent role consists of two primitive roles, namely, INITIATOR and DOER, and that they can be bundled or split (Lundin 2003; Sigurðsson and Wood 2021). In this paper, as opposed to (1), (3) is proposed, where Voice is always Voice[+D] and can be recursive (notated as Voice₁ and Voice₂). I will show that canonical passives are Voice₂-over-Voice₁ and noncanonical passives, subsuming anticausatives and (Turkish-type) reflexives, are Voice₁.

(3) a. Passive: [Voice_{P2} DP_{1i} [Voice_{P1} DP_{2j} [VP *t_i*]]] — canonical passive

b. Anticausative: [Voice_{P1} DP_{1i} [VP *t_i*]] — noncanonical passive

Transitive-passive distinction is thus not attributed to dedicated active and nonactive varieties of Voice but to the type of Merge that is applied in introducing DPs through a Voice head. If external merge (EM) applies, a transitive structure is yielded and if internal merge (IM) applies, a passive structure, canonical or noncanonical, is yielded. The distinction between canonical and noncanonical passives comes down to the distinction in height between the landing sites of the promoted internal argument. This is ultimately dependent on which of EM and IM is applied. If DP is introduced by Voice₁ (VP-selecting Voice) via EM, then it is an external argument, and

¹ Many researchers have attempted to validate various diagnostics as evidence for the absence of external arguments in passives. However, their diagnostics are not true evidence. Absence of evidence is not evidence of absence.

a transitive is yielded, from which a canonical passive is yielded. If DP is introduced by Voice1 via IM, then a noncanonical passive is yielded. In either case, an internal argument is promoted, which is what gives rise to the syncretic nature of various voice constructions. *U*-syncretism and other types of voice-syncretism thus arises where an internal argument is promoted to Spec of a Voice head or referentially linked up with it. Transitive marking blocks *u*-syncretism because when a DP is externally merged by Voice1, its Spec is closed for internal argument promotion, thereby failing the spell-out as passive morphology (*u*-syncretic morphology). Since an internal argument can be promoted to Spec of Voice2, with Spec of Voice1 occupied by an external argument, overt or implicit, Voice2 is naturally spelled out by passive morphology. This is why canonical passives, although lacking the unaccusative syntax, in addition to noncanonical passives, which have the unaccusative syntax, can exhibit *u*-syncretism.

All this remains unexplained under the Voice[−D] approach without making stipulations such as the active-nonactive assumption. Moreover, the Voice[−D] approach fails to account for causative-reflexive syncretism, analogous to *u*-syncretism, in languages such as Mongolian (cf. Section 6). In contrast, the Voice[+D] readily account for all the syncretic constructions.

An important consequence of the Voice[+D] approach to *u*-syncretism will be that UG does not allow variation of Voice as a syntactic head, allowing only Voice[+D]. This is contrary, theoretically, to the Voice[−D] conjecture but complies, empirically, with many facts pointing to the presence of external arguments in the syntax for both passives and transitives (Landau 2010; Collins 2024) and that of internal arguments as subjects of embedded passives (Bai 2026).

This paper is organized as follows. Section 2 illustrates the difference between canonical and low passives and shows that agents are suppressed in the latter but not in the former. Section 3 argues that agents are split into INITIATOR and DOER, the first of which is suppressed in short canonical passives (SCP) but not in long canonical passives (LCP). Section 4 presents an analysis in which Voice heads recursively occur in passives, yielding a Split VoiceP structure. Sections 5 and 6 explain passive-anticausative syncretism and passive/causative-reflexive syncretism based on the Split VoiceP framework, illustrating that voice-syncretism arises where an internal argument is promoted or referentially linked up to Spec of a Voice head. Section 7, concluding this paper, suggests that a Split VoiceP structure is universally available for all voice constructions and that voice semantics is not part of the syntactic head Voice.

2. Agents are suppressed in low passives but not in canonical passives

Key's (2024) approach to passive derivation and *u*-syncretism fails because it is grounded on the assumption that there exists specifierless Voice in the passive syntax. This assumption, though favored by many, is wrong since it was brought about by their presupposition that agentive phrases are always suppressed in passives. While it is true that there are passives that suppress the agent, there must be those that do not. So, in approaching passive-related phenomena, including *u*-syncretism, distinction must first be made between agent-suppressing and agent-projecting passives. No currently known theories are successful in clarifying the distinction. This section is devoted to doing so, based on a careful examination of cross-linguistic empirical facts. Let us begin by noting the oblique phrase, whose status has been controversial among researchers. Some researchers take it as a syntactic argument while others take it as an adjunct. As has been noted by Collins (2005, 2024), Huang et al. (2009), Landau (2010), Müller (2019), and Sulemana (2022), there is plenty of convincing cross-linguistic evidence that the oblique phrase is projected as a syntactic argument in canonical passives.

To begin with, the oblique phrase in passives can act as a binder of a reflexive pronoun and/or an anaphor, a controller of PRO, and a licenser of a depictive secondary predicate, cross-linguistically, indicating that it is a syntactic argument. The following set of English examples from Collins (2024) are a good illustration of this.

(4) a. That book was written [by John]; all by himself.

- b. The book was written [by John]_i [PRO_i to impress his wife].
- c. That book was written [by John]_i; while PRO_i working at a bakery.
- d. Breakfast is usually eaten [by the campers]_i [PRO_i nude].

That external arguments are not suppressed in the syntax is also true for agglutinating languages such as Japanese and Mongolian. In (5), which is a Japanese passive (of-causative) sentence, the dative agent *Taroo* antecedes the anaphor *kare-zisin* ‘himself’, and in (6), which is a Mongolian passive, the dative agent *bagš* ‘teacher’ antecedes the anaphor *öör* ‘self’, indicating that they are syntactic arguments.

- (5) Hanako-j-ga Taroo-ni kare-zisin_i/*j-no kuruma-kara ori-sase-rare-ta.
 Hanako-NOM Taro-DAT himself-GEN car-from get off-CS-PS-PST
 ‘Hanako was forced/caused to get out of his car (= Taro’s car).’
- (6) Surugčj bagš-d_i (öör_i/*j-in) ger-ees-ni höö-gd-sen.
 student-NOM teacher-DAT self-GEN house-ABL-PSS[3] drive out-PS-PST
 ‘The student was driven out by the teacher from his (own) house (= the teacher’s house).’

Agent-suppressing passives, in contrast, do not allow agentive phrases as syntactic arguments and are cross-linguistically attested in languages such as Greek, Turkish, and Mongolian. In what follows, let us focus on Mongolian, an understudied language.

In Mongolian, passive morphology can tolerate dative phrases, without entailing an agentive interpretation, in cases such as (7) and (8).

- (7) Nad-d hüč nem-gd-sen.
 1SG-DAT strength-NOM add-PS-PST
 ‘For me, strength increased.’ / *‘Strength was added by me.’ (Bai 2023: 27)
- (8) Üüd salhin-d / *Baatar-d nee-gd-sen.
 door wind-DAT / John-DAT open-PS-PST
 ‘The door got opened from the wind / *by Baatar.’ (Bai 2025b: 117)

In (7), the dative phrase is not an agent but rather a recipient or beneficiary. Note that the dative phrase cannot antecede an anaphor; nor does it allow a secondary predicates and control PRO, exemplification left out here. Additionally, the dative phrase occurs before the nominative phrase and is more topical than it. According to Passive Universal 3 in Haspelmath (2024), if active and passive constructions differ with respect to topicality of agent and patient, then the patient is more topical in the passive, or the agent is less topical, or both. This means that the sentence-initial dative phrase, not being less topical, in (7) is not an agent normally interpreted for canonical passives. In another case, as in (8), the dative phrase is tolerated only where it expresses natural force such as wind and rain, which is not an agent but rather a cause (not causer). However, (8), and (7) as well, feeds the Passive Voice Alternation in Haspelmath (2024): In a passive voice alternation, the uncoded alternant is transitive (with A- and P-arguments), and in the coded alternant, the basic A is downgraded, and the basic P corresponds to S. In (7) and (8), the basic P of the base verbs corresponds to a nominative subject phrase. This makes them passive-like constructions but different from canonical passives. While Haspelmath’s (2024) universals are not particularly about the argumental status of the oblique phrase, passives like (4–5) and those like (6–7) do differ regarding whether the oblique phrase is an agent or not.² Note that the latter resemble dyadic anticausatives, where the oblique phrase resembles an applied argument, which is not true of the former.

Passives thus must be distinguished between agent-projecting and agent-suppressing. For the former, the oblique phrase mirrors the interpretation of the external argument in the active (Collins 2024: 99), which is not true for the latter. That is, external arguments are projected in agent-projecting passives in the same way as in transitives, as argued by Collins (2024: ch.6). In this sense, agent-projecting, not agent-suppressing, passives are canonical passives. Agent-

² See Alexiadou et al. (2015), Key (2024), and others for cross-linguistic facts pointing to this passive variation.

suppressing passives, in contrast, are not canonical. As will be clear in following sections, agent-suppressing passives are derived by promoting the internal argument to a position lower than that for canonical passives. In this sense, they are “low passives”.

Notable with low passives is that their syntactic and semantic peculiar properties render them like anticausatives and reflexives, as noted by Alexiadou et al. (2015) on Greek, by Key (2024) on Turkish, and by Bai (2023, 2024) on Mongolian. Their deviance from canonical passives is attributed to the demotion of the agent to a non-core argument or suppression of it, an issue to address in Section 3.

Importantly, agent-suppression in low passives must not be used for claiming that passives generally lack agentive arguments. Canonical passives readily allow agentive arguments, which are KPs in the form of either PP or case-marked DP (Collins 2024). Notable is that in canonical passives, agentive arguments, when they are implicit, are not prototypical agents but rather “reduced/defective” agents. We move on to this issue in Section 3.

3. Agent-splitting and INITIATOR-suppression

Why, then, are agents disallowed in low passives while they are allowed in canonical passives? How is this correlated with *u*-syncretism? No currently known approaches can neatly answer these questions, without being embarrassed by empirical facts pointing to agent-suppression and agent-projection. In this section, I show that the crux of the matter is to elucidate how suppression of agents and some other element as well interacts with the promotion of internal arguments under (3), repeated as (9) below.

- (9) a. Passive: [_{VoiceP} DP_{1i} [_{VoiceP} DP_{2j} [_{VP} *t_i*]]] — canonical passive
 b. Anticausative and reflexive: [_{VoiceP} DP_{1i} [_{VP} *t_i*]] — noncanonical (low) passive

Concretely, I show that an agent is split into INITIATOR and DOER,³ where either INITIATOR or INITIATOR+DOER (full agent) is suppressed, which leads to the canonical-low variation of passives and *u*-syncretism. Cross-linguistic facts pointing to agent-splitting are readily available. As noted by Lundin (2003: 134), Swedish light verb *lät* takes an external argument that is not the performer of the action denoted by the base verb, as in *Kalle lät öppna dörren* ‘Kalle had the door opened’. Wood and Sigurðsson (2021) further developed this idea in accounting for a similar light verb used in Icelandic indirect causatives. Let us focus on an understudied language, Mongolian, in comparison with Icelandic, in both of which certain constructions exhibit properties pointing to agent-splitting.

The first construction to be noted is the body part causative, where the causative verb expresses a body part action. Such causative verbs and their non-causative variants are used interchangeably. They differ in that the performer and the initiator of the action are separate for the causative variant while they are identical for the non-causative variant. For example, for *tolgoi-goo бүхий-лге* ‘make one’s head lower’ (causative), one is interpreted as the initiator of the action performed by her/his head, while for *tolgoi-goo бүхий* ‘lower one’s head’, (non-causative), one is interpreted as both the initiator and the performer of action, where one’s head is a patient or theme.

Another interesting relevant construction is the unergative causative, which is formed by combining an unergative verb with a causative suffix, as exemplified by (11). In unergative causatives, the action denoted by the subject is interpreted as being out of her/his control. Note that they and corresponding plain unergatives (10) are used interchangeably to denote the same action. They differ regarding whether the action, for example, coughing here, occurs under the control by the subject. The causative form is used when the speaker wants to emphasize that the action is out of control. Note that the intentional adverb *zoriuud* ‘deliberately’ is bad with

³ INITIATOR is responsible for the agentive, sentient aspects of bringing the event about, and a DOER is responsible for performing the physical actions that bring the event about (Sigurðsson and Wood 2021).

the causative form but readily fine with the plain form. This means that the causative morphology *-lga* here functions to “remove” the volition from the subject, as an agency-reducing effect. Importantly, the causative form is not semantically causative despite its causative form, since it does not allow a (reflexive) causee, implicit or overt. That is, there is no causee that can be recovered by the causative morphology, as illustrated in (12). Causative unergatives are thus not reflexive, differing from the reflexive causative such as *haz-uul* ‘have/get oneself bitten’.

(10) Baatar haniya-san.

Baatar-NOM cough-PST

‘Baatar coughed.’

(11) Baatar haniya-lga-san.

Baatar-NOM cough-CS-PST

‘Baatar coughed.’

‘Literally: Baatar made (himself) cough.’

(12) *Baatar öör-ig-öö haniya-lga-san.

Baatar-NOM self-ACC-RX cough-CS-PST

‘Literally: Baatar made himself cough.’

A construction similar to the Mongolian causative unergative is from Icelandic. In Icelandic *láta* causatives, the causative verb *láta* ‘let’ takes an internal argument as a causer, as in (13), which Wood (2015) views as an anticausative-like construction. Notable with this construction is that it lacks an overt performer of the action denoted by the *-st* verb, as indicated by the fact that a canonical agentive phrase is not allowed. What is introduced by *láta* ‘let’ is an internal argument. Wood (2015: 271) states that “if *láta* ‘let’ takes an external argument with an agent role, it would seem that the surface subject is also absorbing that role”. This naturally follows from the fact that the position (i.e., Spec of the head spelled out by *láta* ‘let’) is occupied by an internal argument, thereby preventing an external causer from being merged there. On the other hand, the external argument of *blekkja* ‘deceive’ with *-st* is “eliminated”, that is, unprojected, due to the merger of a higher head spelled out by *láta* ‘let’ (Wood 2015: 273). All this allows us to say that *láta* ‘let’ behaves like an agency-reducing/deleting morpheme.

(13) ??Ég lét blekkjast af Jóni.

I let deceive-st by John

‘Literally: I let myself be deceived by John.’ (Wood 2015: 272)

The non-*-st* causative in Icelandic also points to this conclusion. In (14), *láta* ‘let’ introduces an external causer, where the performer of the action denoted by the base verb is left vague. That is, the performer, which would otherwise be an agent in canonical causatives, remains a non-performer. To put it differently, the agent of *byggja* ‘build’ is “eliminated” due to the merger of the head spelled out by *láta* ‘let’ on top of the projection of *byggja* ‘build’.

(14) Hún lét byggja húsið.

she-NOM let build the house-ACC

‘She made (someone) build the house.’ (Wood 2015: 268)

It is noted that (13) resembles a passive,⁴ and (14) remains a causative. In either case, agency-reducing is observed, which is rendered by stacking the VP-selecting head (i.e., Voice1b; cf. Section 4) under a higher one (i.e., Voice1a; cf. Section 4).⁵

⁴ Wood (2015: 272) states that this construction is somewhere in between an anticausative and a passive.

⁵ Combining the Mongolian case and the Icelandic case, we can see that an additional function of causative morphology is to remove the INITIATOR-related part of the agent meaning, as is the case with the affix *-in-* in Georgian causatives, which Nash (2020) analyzes as a deagentivizing morpheme. Syntactically, it can be treated as an INITIATOR-splitter, which separates INITIATOR from DOER, introducing the former separately as a sort of causer/initiator and leaving the latter alone with “reduced agency”. In this sense, causative morphology is on a par with passive morphology, which often functions to reduce/demote agency.

What we have discussed above is empirical facts showing that agent-splitting is not only semantically but also formally evident. In what follows, I show that suppression of INITIATOR, one of the two split roles, plays a role in distinguishing SCP from LCP.

With both INITIATOR and DOER, an agent is a prototypical agent, and with INITIATOR suppressed, an agent is a defective/reduced agent (Lundin 2003). That is, DOER alone is a non-prototypical, defective “agent” with “reduced agency”. I proceed to show that implicit agents in SCPs are defective rather than prototypical. In other words, the agent is not suppressed but INITIATOR is in SCP. In LCP, in contrast, neither the agent nor INITIATOR is suppressed. Agents, overt or implicit, are thus not suppressed in canonical passives, long or short, where the projection or suppression of INITIATOR leads to their long-short variation.

Note that agents, which have either full or reduced agency, are thus syntactic arguments. This is why they can pass tests for syntactic arguments (cf. Section 2). Interestingly, long and SCPs differ regarding the anaphor-binding test. Only in LCPs can the agent bind an anaphor, as discussed by Huang (2025) and others using Chinese examples.⁶

(15) Nage xiaohai_i bei Zhangsan_j daihui ziji_{i/j}-de jia qu-le.
that child PS Zhangsan bring back self’s home go-PST
‘That child was brought back by Zhangsan to self’s home.’ (ambiguous) (Huang 2025)

(16) Nage xiaohai_i bei daihui ziji_{i/*j}-de jia qu-le.
that child PS bring back self’s home go-PST
‘That child was brought back to self’s home.’ (unambiguous) (Huang 2025)

This means that agents as syntactic arguments in long and SCPs must differ. Importantly, as far as the following data is concerned, whenever binding obtains (for testing INITIATOR), a secondary predicate or PRO-controlling (for testing DOER) can be tolerated, as in (17), but not vice versa, as in (18).

- (17) a. Breakfast is usually eaten by the campers_i for themselves_i.
b. Breakfast is usually eaten nude by the campers_i for themselves_i.
c. Breakfast is usually eaten nude by the campers_i PRO_i to impress their_i wives.
(18) a. Breakfast is usually eaten nude.
b. *Breakfast is usually eaten nude for themselves.
c. *Breakfast is usually eaten nude PRO_i to impress their_i wives.

This allows us to say that overt agents in LCPs are “fuller” than implicit agents in SCPs. It is what overt agents have but implicit agents lack that enables the former to bind an anaphor but blocks the latter to do so.

From this it follows that DOER alone, being an agent, cannot be overt in passives. If it is overt, it must be accompanied by INITIATOR, where the passive is LCP. Note that LCPs are characterized by involving overt INITIATOR in addition to DOER. Thus DOER alone, with reduced agency, is always implicit and that there does not exist “overt DOER” as a (defective) agent, at least in canonical passives. There does not seem to be evidence for the existence of DOER that occurs alone, with INITIATOR remaining implicit, in canonical passives. Instead, we have evidence that whenever DOER is entailed, INITIATOR is also entailed (17).

Summing up this section, cross-linguistically, agents are decomposed into INITIATOR and DOER, which may or may not be suppressed in passives. In low passives, both are suppressed; in SCPs, INITIATOR is suppressed but DOER is not; and in LCPs, both are not suppressed. In what follows, we look at how *u*-syncretism arises where an internal argument is promoted, which interacts with the suppression and projection of agents.

4. Split VoiceP

⁶ This is also true of languages such as Dutch and Norwegian (Schäfer 2012) and Romance languages (Alexiadou et al. 2015: 129).

Key (2024) argues that Voice[–D], either what he calls active Voice or what he calls nonactive Voice, is the locus of *u*-syncretism. A crucial problem with the Voice[–D] approach to passives is that when a functional head, Voice here, is merged with VP, it has to look ahead at whether a dedicated head Pass will be merged above VoiceP. If Voice sees a prospective Pass, then it does not introduce an external argument but introduces an external argument role or a variable, and if it does not see Pass, then it introduces an external argument rather than a variable or a role. Thus, for Key (2024), an overt transitive marker is syntactically vacuous in Turkish canonical passives, while it is not in regular transitives, which remains conceptually undesirable.

In what follows, I show that there is no active-nonactive variation for Voice as a syntactic head and that the syncretic voice morphology in Turkish and other languages as well is the exponent of an argument-introducing Voice, notated as Voice[+D]. I demonstrate that Voice[+D], being an argument-introducer, may introduce either an external argument via EA or an internal argument via IA, which is allowed by Free Merge (Chomsky 2013, 2015). Before providing evidence for this, let us first sketch out the Voice[+D] configuration under Free Merge. Henceforth, Voice[+D] is abbreviated as Voice, just for purposes of simplicity; Voice[+D] is used only where necessary.

First, when Voice on top of VP, notated as Voice1, introduces a DP via EM, a transitive structure is yielded, where transitive marking, overt or null, spells out Voice1; second, when it introduces a DP via IM, a low passive or an anticausative is yielded, where passive morphology spells out Voice1; third, when a higher Voice, notated as Voice2, introduces a DP via IM, a canonical passive structure is yielded, where passive morphology spells out Voice2; fourth, when either Voice1 or Voice2 introduces a DP which is referentially identical, and hence thematically identical, to the in-situ internal argument via EM, a reflexive structure is yielded, where passive morphology spells out Voice1 or causative morphology spells out Voice2.

Notable here is that a passive subject stops over Spec of a Voice head on its way to Spec of TP. I assume that any argument introduced by any Voice head is a potential subject, that is, a predicate-internal subject, notated as sbj1, sbj2, sbj3, etc., where sbj introduced by the highest Voice head is promoted to Spec of TP, becoming the surface subject, notated as SBJ.

(19) Split VoiceP: [TP SBJ ... [VoiceP2 sbj2 [VoiceP1 sbj1 [VP]]] ...]⁷

- (20) a. ... [VoiceP1 DP2_i (=sbj1) Voice1 [VP DP1]] — Transitive
 b. ... [VoiceP1 DP1_i (=sbj1) Voice1 [VP t_i]] — Intransitive
 c. ... [VoiceP2 DP1_i (=sbj2) Voice2 [VoiceP1 DP2 (=sbj1) Voice1 [VP t_i]]] — Passive

Under this approach, not only agents (external arguments) but also passive subjects (internal arguments) are introduced by Voice heads, where Voice is always Voice[+D], a true argument-introducer. That is, Voice is underspecified about the thematic role of the DP it introduces.

We first look at evidence for Voice2 being so. What we need to confirm is that an internal argument is introduced as a passive subject by Voice2. A piece of evidence comes from causative-of-passives in Japanese, exemplified by (21), in which the non-thematic subject of the embedded passive *Hanako* does not surface in Spec of TP but rather in Spec of a head higher than the head which introduces the agent *Taroo*. *Hanako*, the causee here, must be an argument rather than an adjunct since an adjunct does not take accusative case. *Taroo* is also an argument since the agent can antecede an anaphor, as we have seen in Section 3.

- (21) Zi-roo-ga Hanako-o/ni Taroo-ni sikar-are-sase-ta.
 Zi-roo-NOM Hanako-ACC/DAT Taroo-DAT scold-PS-CS-PST
 ‘Zi-roo made Hanako be scolded by Taroo.’ (Tsuji-mura 1996: 259)

In addition to Japanese, English also provides evidence for subjects of canonical passives occurring in Spec of a head lower than T but higher than Voice1/v. The subject of the passive

⁷ See Bai (2025c) for discussion on the possibility that VoiceP can iterate up to VoiceP3, which is strongly evidenced by Japanese causative-of-passives and passive-of-causatives as well as Mongolian transitive-based double causatives formed from a transitive stem. This strengthens the validity of the Split VoiceP approach.

phrase in English transitive expletives (22) and the quantifier *all* in passives (23) does not occupy Spec of TP, indicating that there is an intermediate position for the passive subject. That intermediate position, I argue, is Spec of VoiceP2.

(22) There were three people_i arrested *t_i* at the airport. (McCloskey 1997: 215)

(23) They were all arrested. (Fleisher 2005: 5)

Now we have a look at evidence that Voice1 also introduces an internal argument, as is the case with Voice2. As exemplified by (23), which is an intransitive/anticausative-based causative, the internal argument is promoted to an argument position, thereby being able to bind the anaphor. It is evident that that position is outside VP but inside the causative projection.

(24) [[Taroo_i-ga [Hanako_j-o [*t_j* zibun_{i/j}-no kuruma-kara ori]] -sase] -ta].

Taro-NOM Hanako-ACC self-GEN car-from get off-CS-PST

‘Taro caused Hanako to get out of his/*her car.’ (Pylkkänen 2008: 73)

The causative here is a canonical, that is, productive/syntactic, one, and therefore the causative projection dominates VoiceP1, which is where a lexical causative, akin to the plain transitive, is formed. Accordingly, the causative projection is VoiceP2 atop VoiceP1. It then follows that the accusative causee *Hanako*, the subject of the phrase embedded by VoiceP2, occupies Spec of VoiceP1, where an external argument also occurs in transitives.

(25) [TP [VoiceP2 Taroo_i [VoiceP1 Hanako_j-o [VP *t_j* from self_{i/j}’s car get off] Ø] -sase] -ta].

Note that the accusative causee is not in-situ. This is evidenced by the fact that the productive causative form *ori-sase* ‘cause to come down’ alternates with the lexical causative form *or-os* ‘take down’, where only for the latter does an accusative phrase surface as an object in-situ and fail to bind an anaphor.

Now it is clear that a Voice head, Voice1 or Voice2, always introduces an argument via either EM or IM. As such, there is no Voice[-D] and therefore *u*-syncretism turns out to be associated with Voice[+D], contrary to Key (2024) and others.

In what follows, I will elaborate on VoiceP1. Voice1 may be further split into two heads, notated as Voice1a and Voice1b,⁸ taking INITIATOR and DOER respectively, as in (26b).

(26) b. [VoiceP1(a+b) INITIATOR+DOER [VP]] (not split)

a. [VoiceP1a INITIATOR [VoiceP1b DOER [VP]]] (split)

Importantly, VoiceP1a may or may not be projected above VoiceP1b. When VoiceP1a is projected, a prototypical agent, with both INITIATOR and DOER, is available, and when it is not, DOER remains alone, as illustrated in (27). This latter case is what happens to SCPs.

(27) [VoiceP2 DP1_i [VoiceP1 DP2 (DOER_{implicit}) [VP *t_i*]]] (short canonical passive)

For LCPs, in contrast, INITIATOR and DOER are not split but rather bundled, as in (28).⁹

(28) [VoiceP2 DP1_i [VoiceP1 DP2 (INITIATOR+DOER) [VP V *t_i*]]] (long canonical passive)

Notable is that as illustrated in (29), an internal argument (DP1) can be promoted to Spec of VoiceP1a, with Spec of VoiceP1b occupied by a new DP (DP2), yielding the long version of low passive,¹⁰ which resembles the dyadic anticausative.¹¹ In this case, DP2 is not DOER, that is, not an agent, in a stricter sense. It is a non-core oblique argument instead.

⁸ Voice1a and Voice1b here correspond to Nie (2020) and Wood and Sigurðsson’s (2021) upper Voice and lower Voice respectively.

⁹ This means that where INITIATOR and DOER are separate, VoiceP1 does not feed passivization. This is compatible with the fact that agent-splitting constructions such as the body part causative and the causative unergative in Mongolian as well as the *lät* causative in Swedish and the *láta* causative in Icelandic, discussed in Section 3, all do not feed passivization. The reason why agent-splitting is not subject to embedment under a higher Voice would be piling up of VoiceP layers in the syntax or that of Voice suffixes in the morphology to the limit of human brain’s capacity is not or less tolerated.

¹⁰ Where the oblique phrase (DP2) is not expressed, the structure is a short version of low passive.

¹¹ In Pylkkänen’s (2008) term, DP2 would be an applied argument, introduced by what she calls Low Applicative head. Kallulli and Roberts (2024) treat all non-core arguments and agents (DP2 here) alike, arguing that they are merged in the same position, namely, Spec of vP, which corresponds to VoiceP1 here.

(29) [_{VoiceP1a} DP1_i [_{VoiceP1b} DP2 (oblique) [_{VP} *t_i*]]] (low passive: dyadic anticausative)

Where, as illustrated in (30), VoiceP1a is not projected, VoiceP1b remains VoiceP. Voice1 introduces DP1 via IM, yielding a monadic anticausative, where Voice1 is spelled out as dedicated anticausative morphology, which is supposed to be different than dedicated passive morphology.¹² Notable here is that the promotion of an internal argument to Spec of VoiceP1 renders it closed for a new argument. That is, with an internal argument promoted to Spec of VoiceP1, no DP, which would otherwise be an oblique phrase, is merged there.

(30) [_{VoiceP1} DP1_i [_{VP} *t_i*]]] (anticausative: monadic)

Where VoiceP1 is split, as in (31), if VoiceP1b introduces a DP (DP2) as an oblique argument via EM and VoiceP1a introduces another (DP3), a causative-like structure is yielded.¹³

(31) [_{VoiceP1a} DP3 [_{VoiceP1b} DP2 [_{VP} DP1]]] (noncanonical causative)

Particularly notable with (31) is that it alternates with (29), which is a dyadic anticausative structure, regarding whether EM or IM applies in introducing a DP into Spec of VoiceP1a. When EM applies, a new DP (DP3) is introduced and acts as a causer/initiator, where INITIATOR and DOER (a non-core argument, strictly speaking) are separate, with causative morphology spelling out Voice1a. Alternatively, IM applies, where an old DP (DP1) is introduced but it is not a causer/initiator this time, with causative morphology spelling out Voice1a. This is to say that the promoted DP1 in Spec of VoiceP1a and DP2 in Spec of VoiceP1b are not split elements. This is why agent-splitting can often be morphologically transparent in (indirect) causatives while it can never be so in long low passives (dyadic anticausatives). However, importantly, it is the case that a non-core argument (DP2) occupies Spec of VoiceP1b in variably in noncanonical causatives and long low passives, the difference between coming down to the EM-IM distinction for introducing a DP into Spec of VoiceP1a. It is noted that the causative-passive alternation between (31) and (29) parallels with that between canonical productive causatives (32) and LCP (28).

(32) [_{VoiceP2} DP3 [_{VoiceP1} DP2 [_{VP} DP1]]] (canonical causative)

Summing up this section, agent/INITIATOR-suppression does not entail Voice[−D], which is a defective head. Rather, a Voice[+D] analysis is indicated, where an internal argument is introduced by a Voice head via IM before it reaches the surface subject position. It is because an internal argument is promoted to Spec of a Voice head, rendering a passive-like reading, that Voice-syncretism such as *u*-syncretism arises. As such, *u*-syncretism or other types of Voice-syncretism is not attributed to a dedicated Voice[−D] head. There does not exist so-called nonactive Voice in syntax.

What can be implied by the correlation between Split VoiceP and low passives as well as noncanonical causatives is that role demotion, for example, from agent to recipient/beneficiary/goal, and that agent-splitting is due to the structural push-down by higher VoiceP layer. Specifically, consecutive Voice layers get a lower layer squashed up against a higher layer, thereby the former undergoes truncation and/or the argument in its Spec undergoes role dissociation or mutation. However, such structural push-down is not obligatory. In canonical passives as well as canonical causatives, a lower Voice layer is not squashed up against a higher one, where no agent-splitting or role demotion occurs. Combining this with the nature of Voice as an underspecified argument-introducer, it is implied that voice constructions are built by formal, not thematic, relations between arguments, which are potential subjects,

¹² See Section 5 for actual cases in which low-passive morphology is distinct from anticausative morphology.

¹³ Berro et al. (2025) hold that in indirect causatives in Basque, the causee (DP2 here), which they view as an Affectee of the action, is introduced by Voice1b (their low Voice), which, they state (2025: 1296), resembles Pylkkänen's (2008) Applicative head. Chen (2024: 9) holds that Affectees (roughly identical to causees) in causatives are introduced by Applicative. Interestingly, Spec of VoiceP1b can be "empty" in Icelandic, according to Wood (2015), who argues that VoiceP1b (his "lower VoiceP") is truncated, with Voice1b being a "vacuous head" and Voice1a being realized as causative morphology.

that is, predicate-internal subjects. In this sense, predicate-internal subjects are not limited to transitives; they are available across voice constructions including transitives and passives, and across matrix and embedded clauses/VoicePs.

5. Passive versus anticausative

Many languages feature passive-anticausative syncretism. In this section, I will explain it using Turkish and Mongolian data, where identical morphology can be employed for expressing both passive semantics and anticausative semantics in each language. What follows is a summary of Key's (2024) description of Turkish anticausative morphology. Turkish employs two strategies in expressing an anticausative meaning: the passive suffix *-Il* (as well as its allomorphs *-n* and *-In*) and the intransitive light verb *-ol*. *-Il* expresses an anticausative meaning where it is affixed to a non-transitive-marked verb stem. It expresses a rigidly interpreted passive meaning where it is affixed to a transitive stem marked by a causative suffix or the active light verb *eD-*. Since a predicate with passive morphology but an anticausative meaning instantiates the low passive, *-Il* is a low passive marker with a null-transitive stem while it is a canonical passive marker with an overtly marked transitive stem. The intransitive light verb *-ol* is used to derive an unaccusative verb from a non-verbal base; it is not a passive marker.

Very similar to Turkish, Mongolian employs both passive morphology *-gd* and a verbalizing (intransitivizing) suffix *-r* for anticausatives, analogous to Turkish *-ol*. As illustrated in (33), *-gd*, when used as an anticausative (low passive) marker, it can only be attached to a transitive stem without an overt marker, whether it is the verbalizing (transitivizing) suffix *-l*,¹⁴ analogous to Turkish *eD-*, or a causative suffix (*UUL*, *LGA*, and *AA*),¹⁵ analogous to Turkish causative suffixes (*-Ar*, *-Art*, *-Ir*, *-It*, *-t*, and *-Dir*). When attached to a transitive/causative-marking stem, *-gd* can only express a canonical/rigid passive meaning. As in (34), the inchoative suffix *-r* functions to verbalize (intransitivize) a non-verbal base and the causative *-l* functions to both verbalize (transitivize) a non-verbal base and introduce an external argument.

(33) *nem-gd* 'increase (intr)' (passive of unmarked transitive (low passive/anticausative))

ṣat-aa-gd 'be burned' (passive of marked transitive/causative (canonical passive))

**med-üül-gd* 'be reported' (passive of marked transitive/causative)

(34) *hag-r* 'break (intr)'; *hag-l* 'break (tr)'

Key (2024: 352–353) analyzes both types of anticausatives as associated with the so-called nonactive Voice, a variety of Voice[–D], where *Il*-marked anticausatives (low passives here) in Turkish are derived by attacking Voice[–D] (his Voice_{NACT}) onto the verbalizing head *v* and *ol*-marked ones by bundling the two heads into one. Similar analysis would be carried over to Mongolian, for Key (2024). Under the proposed Voice[+D] analysis, however, the *Il*-marked anticausative and the *gd*-marked one in Mongolian as well, being the low passive, is derived by promoting an internal argument to Spec of VoiceP1a, as in (35), and the *ol*-marked anticausative and the *r*-marked one in Mongolian as well, is derived by promoting an internal argument to Spec of VoiceP1b, as in (36). For the former, *-Il* and *-gd* spell out Voice1a, with Voice1b remaining null but introducing DP2 as a non-agent oblique/ablative argument, which may be absent at PF, as in *Pankart (sert rüzgar-dan) yırt-ıl-dı* 'The banner tore (from the strong wind)',

¹⁴ Traditional studies on Mongolian syntax including grammar books have not taken *-r* and *-l* as an alternating equipollent pair of inchoative and causative suffixes. Bai (2025a), however, includes *-l* in the list of Mongolian causative suffixes, characterizing it as a realization of a terminal node, which is a bundle of Voice and the verbalizing light verb *v*.

¹⁵ Canonical passives are always derived from an *AA*-marked causative stem or an unmarked transitive stem. Low passives are not derived from an *AA*-marked causative stem but from an unmarked transitive stem. In this respect, *AA* is on a par with the causative suffixes and the light verb *eD-* in Turkish. Specifically, passives derived from a marked causative stem are always canonical passives and *u*-syncretism arises where causative/transitive marking is null (Key 2024). See Bai (2025a, 2025c) and Bao et al. (2025) for detailed discussion on the morphosyntactic properties of causative suffixes and their interaction with passive suffixes in Mongolian.

an example from Key (2024 : 348 (his (40))). For the latter, *-ol* and *-r* spell out Voice1, which is in fact a bundle of Voice1b and *v*, the verbalizer.

(35) [_{VoiceP1a} DP1_i [_{VoiceP1b} DP2 (oblique) *-il* / *-gd* [_{VP} *t_i*]]] (low passive: dyadic anticausative)

(36) [_{VoiceP1} DP1_i *-ol* / *-r* [_{VP} *t_i*]] (anticausative: monadic)

That Spec of VoiceP1b is occupied by a non-agent oblique phrase in low passives is emphasized by the fact that the same is true of noncanonical causatives in Mongolian. Noncanonical causatives are causatives in which the dative phrase is not a causee agent but a recipient or beneficiary or goal. For example, in (37), the dative phrase is interpreted as a receiver of the information/report, not the performer of the getting-to-know action. This is evidenced by the fact that adverbial modification targets the whole verb rather than the base verb. For example, *hurdan med-üül* means “report sth to sb quickly” rather than “let sb quickly learn about sth”. Interestingly, the same holds true of the passive variant. *Hurdan med-gd* means “inform sb of sth quickly” rather than “make sth known to sb quickly”.

(37) Baatar Ulaan-d en yabdal-ig med-üül/gd-sen.

Baatar-NOM Ulaan-DAT this matter-ACC know-CS/PS-PST

‘Baatar reported this incident to Ulaan.’ (for *med-üül*)

‘Baatar informed Ulaan of this incident.’ (for *med-gd*)

Given this, low passives and noncanonical causatives do not differ in that for both, Spec of VoiceP1b is occupied by a non-agent oblique argument. They, however, differ in that in low passives, Spec of VoiceP1a is occupied by a promoted internal argument while in noncanonical causatives, it is occupied by INITIATOR.

The promotion of an internal argument to Spec of a Voice head renders passives, anticausatives, reflexives, etc. syncretic, on the one hand, licenses the unaccusative syntax to low passives, as a *u*-syncretic effect, on the other hand. In this sense, what is described as *u*-syncretism in fact should be described as *p*-syncretism, for passive-syncretism, as a case of voice-syncretism. This is so at least in Turkish/Mongolian-type languages.

Regarding passive semantics, I argue that it is not the meaning of Voice, which is simply an argument-introducer (a potential-subject-introducer, strictly speaking (cf. Bai 2025c)), as is the case with morphological causatives, where causative semantics is not part of the syntax (Nie 2020). Rather, passive semantics, I argue, the meaning interpreted for a configuration in which an internal argument is promoted, whether the agent is suppressed or not; it is assigned to the configuration at LF. Due to the internal argument promotion to Spec of VoiceP1 (VoiceP1a or VoiceP1b) in low passives, a non-rigid passive reading arises, where agents are suppressed to oblique phrases as non-core arguments with. This is evident cross-linguistically, for example, in the languages discussed in this paper including Turkish, Mongolian, and Icelandic.

6. Passive/Causative versus reflexive

Many languages including Turkish and Mongolian are syncretic with respect to passives and reflexives. In Turkish, the passive-reflexive syncretism is associated with the VP-selecting Voice, Voice1 in this paper.

Key (2024) argues that Turkish reflexives are derived over the same structure as the anticausative. That is, for Key (2024), a reflexive structure is associated with so-called nonactive Voice. Under the analysis proposed here, however, Turkish-type reflexives are derived where Spec of VoiceP1 is occupied by a DP coreferential with the in-situ internal argument which is absent from PF. It naturally follows from the fact that they, with passive morphology *-il*, are formed from a stem lacking overt transitive marking that INITIATOR is not involved in them, which gives rise to the reflexive-passive syncretism.

Unlike the Turkish case, exemplified by (38), what may qualify as reflexives in Mongolian are not passive-marked but rather causative-marked, where there is an implicit reflexive causee,

as in (39–40).¹⁶

(38) Küçük kız tart-ıl-dı.

little girl weigh-NACT-PST-1SG

a. ‘The little girl was weighed.’ (passive)

b. ‘The little girl weighed herself.’ (reflexive) (Key 2024: 353)

(39) Bi nohai-d haz-uul-san.

I dog-DAT bite-CS-PST

‘I got bitten by a dog.’

‘I had a dog bite me.’

(40) Bi nohai-d öör-ig-öö haz-uul-san.

I dog-DAT self-ACC-RX bite-CS-PST

‘I got myself bitten by a dog.’

‘I had a dog bite me.’

In (39), *haz-uul* ‘cause to bite’ is formed from a transitive, not anticausative, stem and does not participate in causative-inchoative alternation. Notably, such causatives express that the causer takes the responsibility for the action performed by the dative element. In this sense, the causer is INITIATOR. The causative suffix is thus functioning to suppress INITIATOR with respect to the implicit causee in Spec of VoiceP1. In terms of a reflexive reading of (39), for example, “I got (myself) bitten by the dog”, the implicit causee is coreferential with the causer subject.

Unlike Turkish reflexives, Mongolian reflexives are derived over VoiceP2, not VoiceP1. Therefore, the syncretism with reflexives in Mongolian is not *u*-syncretism since *u*-syncretism construed in the strict sense is associated with VoiceP1. Note that VoiceP2 is irrelevant to unaccusative syntax.

This leads to the high-low distinction of voice-syncretism, where rigidly understood *u*-syncretism is low-voice-syncretism, which covers low passives, anticausatives, and Turkish-type reflexives, while the Mongolian-type (passive-)causative-reflexive syncretism is high-voice-syncretism, which covers (canonical passives), canonical causatives and Mongolian-type reflexives. Notably, passives are correlated with both high- and low-voice-syncretism. In this sense, voice-syncretism is best described as *p*-syncretism, and *u*-syncretism turns out to be a subcase of *p*-syncretism. Note that the contradiction between Key’s (2024) first and third claims noted in Section 1 is due to his negligence of the high-low distinction of voice-syncretism. The cause of the negligence and hence the contradiction is the failure to identify internal argument promotion as the trigger of *u*-syncretism.

When it comes to causative-reflexive syncretism, many languages differ from Mongolian. Unlike Mongolian, which features two-way *u*-syncretism, Turkish allows four-way *u*-syncretism — passive-anticausative-reflexive-impersonal (Key 2024), and Greek allows three-way *u*-syncretism — passive-anticausative-reflexive (Embick 2004; Alexiadou 2014; Alexiadou et al. 2015).

7. Consequences and implications

Concluding this paper, *u*-syncretism must be approached in terms of Voice[+D] (argument-introducing Voice) rather than Voice[–D] (non-argument-introducing Voice). Specifically, either a VP-selecting Voice (Voice1) or a higher Voice (Voice2) may be the locus of *u*-syncretism (what is spelled out by *u*-syncretic morphology). This is consistent with the fact that rigidly construed *u*-syncretism, “*u*” for “unaccusative”, arises only where transitive marking is null at least in Turkish and Mongolian. If *u*-syncretism is understood, non-rigidly, to cover the syncretism exhibited by both canonical and low passives, then transitive marking is not

¹⁶ The coreferentiality between the causer and the causee leads to the fact that this type of causatives is interpreted like either causatives or passives or reflexives. Authors such as Washio (1993) discussed this construction as a species of the passive.

necessarily null for it given that canonical passives can be derived from a marked transitive stem and they must be in languages such as Turkish. What connects the various voice constructions, centered on (canonical and low) passives, the voice proper, with each other is thus internal argument promotion to Spec of a Voice head rather than the purported absence of external arguments. I then conclude that *u*-syncretism arises where an internal argument is introduced by Voice via IM or where an argument referentially linked up with an in-situ internal argument is introduced via EM. The former case gives rise to passive-anticausative syncretism and the latter passive-reflexive syncretism. In either case, passive morphology and causative morphology as well (in Mongolian-type languages) spells out a Voice head, Voice1 or Voice2.

An important consequence of this is that not only a lower Voice (Voice1) but also a higher one (Voice2) is not specified as transitive or passive, nor is it specified as active or nonactive. As such, Voice is underspecified about the type of argument it introduces. Either an external argument or an internal one can be introduced by Voice, which is allowed by Free Merge. Voice is thus also underspecified about its associated semantic interpretation in the syntax. Voice semantics is assigned to syntactic configurations with VoiceP, split or not, at LF. It does not come from a Voice head itself. Besides, Voice is devoid of any dedicated feature specifying transitive versus passive voice or active versus nonactive voice. Thus, voice-specifying features like [active] and [nonactive] are not syntactic primitives. Consequently, the syntax of voice/Voice, I argue, comes down to “Voice plus Free Merge”, which is available by UG, rather than to active/nonactive Voice plus formal semantics as discussed by Bruening (2013) and subsequent research, where the latter is deviant from the simplism of Minimalist syntax.

References

- Alexiadou, Artemis. 2014. Active, middle, and passive: the morpho-syntax of Voice. *Catalan Journal of Linguistics* 13, 19–40.
- Alexiadou, Artemis, Elena Anagnostopoulou, and Florian Schäfer. 2015. *External Arguments in Transitivity Alternations: A Layering Approach*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Bai, Chigchi. 2023. A diachronic change in Mongolian passives viewed from *nemegde*- (In Mongolian). *Mongolian Language* 3, 27–31.
- Bai, Chigchi. 2024. On the valence of passive verbs in Mongolian. *Journal of Inner Mongolia University* 6, 18–25.
- Bai, Chigchi. 2025a. Morphology, syntax, and semantics of Mongolian causatives: An interface analysis. *Proceedings of The 12th International Congress of Mongolists* 4, 203–226.
- Bai, Chigchi. 2025b. The structure of passive sentences in *The Secret History of the Mongols* and the diachronic change in passive voice in Mongolian. *Minority Languages of China* 3, 109–119.
- Bai, Chigchi. 2025c. Mirror principle and Split VoiceP: Evidence from Mongolian and Japanese. *Asian Languages and Linguistics* 6, 253–286.
- Baker, Mark. 1985. The mirror principle and morphosyntactic explanation. *Linguistic Inquiry* 16, 373–415.
- Bao, Chunmei, Chigchi Bai, and Togtambayar Wu. 2025. A unified account of passives and causatives: The case of Mongolian and Japanese. *Proceedings of the 18th Workshop on Altaic Formal Linguistics (MIT Working Papers in Linguistics 97)*, 31–40.
- Berro, Ane, Ane Odria and Beatriz Fernández. 2025. Indirect causatives in Basque: The syntax of implicit causees. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 43, 1285–1325.
- Bruening, Benjamin. 2013. By phrases in passives and nominals. *Syntax* 16, 1–41.
- Chen, Mingjiang. 2025. A decomposition analysis of Agents. *Glossa: a journal of general linguistics* 9, 1–42.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2013. Problems of projection. *Lingua* 130, 33–49.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2015. Problems of projection: Extensions. In Elisa Di Domenico, Cornelia

- Hamann, and Simona Matteini (eds.), *Structures, Strategies and Beyond: Studies in Honor of Adriana Belletti*, 3–16. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Collins, Chris. 2005. A smuggling approach to the passive in English. *Syntax* 8, 81–120. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9612.2005.00076.x>.
- Collins, Chris. 2024. *Principles of Argument Structure: A Merge-based Approach*. Cambridge, MA.: MIT Press.
- Embick, David. 2004. Unaccusative syntax and verbal alternations. In Artemis Alexiadou, Elena Anagnostopoulou, and Martin Everaert (eds.), *The Unaccusativity Puzzle: Explorations of the Syntax-Lexicon Interface*, 137–158. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Fleisher, Nicholas. 2005. Passive *get*, causative *get*, and the phasehood of passive vP. *Proceedings of CLS 41*. Chicago: Chicago Linguistic Society.
- Givón, Talmy. 1971. Historical syntax and synchronic morphology: An archaeologist's field trip. *Chicago Linguistic Society* 7, 394–415.
- Haspelmath, Martin. 2024. Passive constructions: Universals and language description. <https://lingbuzz.net/lingbuzz/008340>.
- Huang, C.-T. James. 2025. On implicit arguments in syntactic structure. Talk presented at *International Conference on Formal Linguistics 2025*, held in Guangzhou, China.
- Huang, C-T. James, Li Y-H. Audrey and Li Yafei. 2009. *The Syntax of Chinese*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Kallulli, Dalina and Ian Roberts. 2024. On the relation between Voice and Case: An Agree-based approach. Manuscript, available at [lingbuzz/008426](https://lingbuzz.net/lingbuzz/008426).
- Key, Grey. 2024. Voice in Turkish: Re-thinking *u*-syncretism. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 43, 331–384.
- Landau, Idan. 2010. The explicit syntax of implicit arguments. *Linguistic Inquiry* 41, 357–88.
- Legate, Julie Anne. 2014. *Voice and v: Lessons from Acehnese*. Cambridge: MIT Press.
- Legate, Julie Anne, Faruk Akkuş, Milena Šereikaite, and Don Ringe. 2020. On passives of passives. *Language* 96, 771–818.
- Lundin, Katarina. 2003. *Small Clauses in Swedish: Towards a Unified Account*. Doctoral Dissertation, Lund University.
- McCloskey, Jim. 1997. Subjecthood and subject positions. In Liliane Haegeman (ed.), *Elements of Grammar*, 197–235. Kluwer Academic Publishers.
- Müller, Gereon. 2019. The short life cycle of external arguments in German passive derivations. In Andrew Murphy (ed.), *Linguistische Arbeits Berichte* 94, 55–112. Leipzig University.
- Nash, Léa. 2020. Causees are not agents. In Bar-Asher Siegal, Elitzur A. & Boneh, Nora (eds.), *Perspectives on Causation*, 349–394. Cham: Springer.
- Pylkkänen, Liina. 2008. *Introducing Arguments*. Cambridge: MIT Press.
- Schäfer, Florian. 2008. *The Syntax of (Anti-)causatives: External Arguments on Change-of-state Contexts*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Schäfer, Florian. 2012. The passive of reflexive verbs and its implications for theories of binding and case. *Journal of Comparative Germanic Linguistics* 15, 213–68.
- Sigurðsson, Einar Freyr, and Jim Wood. 2021. On the implicit argument of Icelandic indirect causatives. *Linguistic Inquiry* 52, 579–626.
- Sulemana, Abdul-Razak. 2022. Passive without morphology: A case for implicit arguments. *Linguistic Variation* 25, 168–200.
- Tsujimura, Natsuko. 1996. *An Introduction to Japanese Linguistics*. Cambridge: Blackwell.
- Washio, Ryuichi. 1993. When causatives mean passive: A cross-linguistic perspective. *Journal of East Asian Linguistics* 2, 45–90.
- Wood, Jim. 2015. *Icelandic Morphosyntax and Argument Structure*. Switzerland: Springer.
- Wood, Jim and Einar Freyr Sigurðsson. 2021. On the interaction of reflexives and periphrastic causatives in Icelandic. *Proceedings of the 44th Annual Penn*

Linguistics Conference, 257–266.